

Current Hiring Trends in the Animation & VFX Industry

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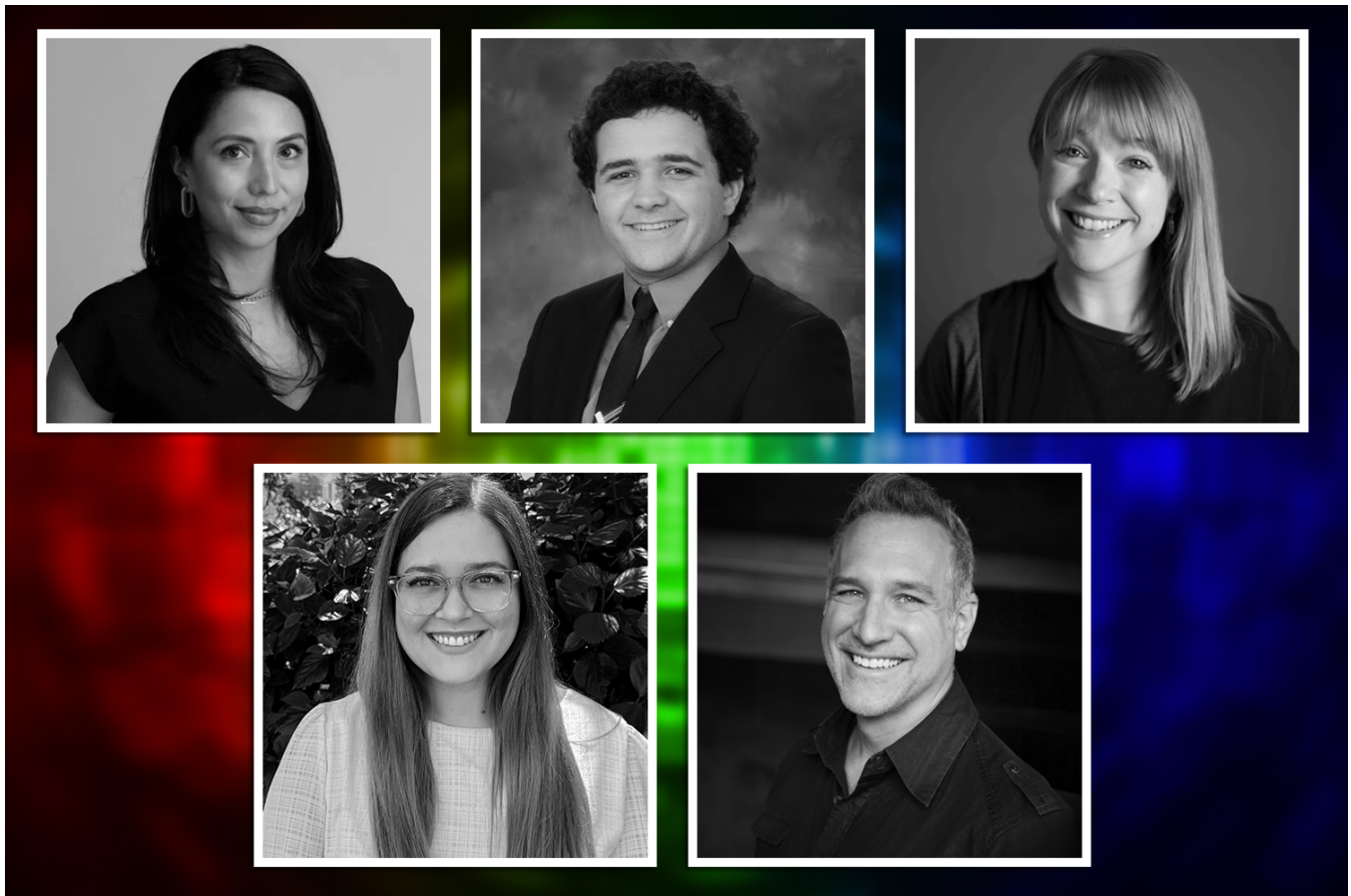


Figure 1: Featured Panelists Tiffany Purkeypile (Laika), Benjamin Noble (The Third Floor), Kathleen Ruffalo (Framestore), Caitlin Dietz, and Moderator CK Olsen (University of Iowa).



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Abstract

The computer animation and VFX industry is navigating a period of sustained transition, marked by technological acceleration, shifting production models, and cyclical workforce contraction and expansion. For those responsible for building and sustaining creative teams, hiring today involves not only identifying talent, but balancing training investment, long-term growth, and uncertainty within an evolving global ecosystem. This panel foregrounds that

first-person reality. Current Hiring Trends in the Animation and VFX Industry convenes recruiting leaders from across major animation, VFX, and design studios, including Framestore, Laika, The Third Floor, and more. Rather than offering a prescriptive how-to, the panel is designed as a candid, comparative conversation shaped by those actively navigating hiring decisions, internship programs, and evolving skill demands. For students, early-career artists, and technologists, hiring is often an opaque experience. For educators, the challenge lies in preparing graduates for realities that shift faster than curricula can. This panel aims to provide an accurate snapshot of the current job landscape, clarifying how internship and entry-level pipelines actually function, outlining the flow of the recruiting and application process from multiple studio perspectives, and identifying the skills and areas of focus most in demand today. Panelists will also address best practices for pursuing work in this highly competitive field, alongside opportunities for informal connection and dialogue. Moderated by an animator/educator with a broad industry background and direct engagement in student recruitment pathways, the session emphasizes shared insight over studio competition. Through aligned concerns, nuanced perspective, and respectful disagreement, the panel models how knowledge can be shared across institutional boundaries in service of a healthier, more transparent ecosystem. By equipping artists and educators with clearer information and realistic expectations, this conversation helps transform uncertainty into more targeted preparation, and supports more sustainable pathways from education into professional practice.

CCS Concepts

• **Social and professional topics** → **Professional topics; Professional topics**; • **Applied computing** → *Media arts*; • **Human-centered computing** → *Collaborative and social computing*.

Keywords

Hiring practices, Recruitment, Internships, Animation, Visual Effects (VFX), Computing education, Career pathways

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1 Motivation and Timeliness

The animation and visual effects industry is experiencing a sustained period of transition, driven by rapid tool adoption, evolving global production models, and recurring cycles of workforce contraction and expansion. While volatility has long been part of the field, its compounded effects have increased uncertainty for studios, educators, and emerging artists alike. Hiring teams are now tasked not only with identifying talent, but with balancing training investment, specialization, long-term growth, and organizational sustainability across very different production contexts. Global VFX, stop-motion, feature animation, and previs-focused production houses each face distinct constraints, timelines, and

expectations, yet all draw from the same emerging talent pool. This panel responds to a practical need for clarity by offering a first-person snapshot of how hiring pipelines currently operate across these varied environments. Rather than presenting a prescriptive how-to, the session is designed as a comparative conversation that foregrounds real differences, shared pressures, and the evolving signals studios use to assess readiness.

2 Focus and Guiding Questions

The discussion is organized around a small set of shared questions that invite both alignment and contrast:

- What has changed most in how studios assess entry-level and early-career applicants?
- Which skills, habits, and signals matter most for internships and junior roles today?
- How do recruiting pipelines typically function from application to interview to offer?
- Where do studio needs, educational preparation, and applicant expectations align or diverge?
- What misconceptions persist around hiring, and what forms of transparency are realistically possible?

This panel does not seek consensus. Instead, the goal is to surface concrete differences, shared constraints, and actionable clarity for artists, educators, and folks seeking to make a career in this fascinating, but oft misunderstood industry.

3 Proposed Panel Structure

The moderator and panelists kick off the session by framing current industry conditions at a high level, introducing each panelist's studio context and hiring scope, and setting the stage for the conversation to ensue, beginning with defining key terms such as internship, trainee, junior role, and generalist versus specialist. The core of the session centers on comparative discussion across studio pipelines, production cycles, and hiring constraints. The moderator actively prompts contrast and clarification, encouraging respectful disagreement where perspectives diverge and highlighting areas of alignment when they naturally emerge. Panelists offer first-person insight into contemporary hiring realities, including current and emerging skill needs, specialization trends, applicant evaluation criteria, portfolio and reel review, interview practices, internship and junior artist opportunities, entry-level readiness, and the relationship between craft fundamentals and emerging tools. The session concludes by summarizing key insights and open questions, with an emphasis on takeaways that artists and educators can apply immediately. Audience participation is prioritized throughout, with dedicated time reserved at the end for additional questions and direct interaction.

4 Audience and Expected Impact

The panel is intended for students, early-career artists, educators, and industry professionals seeking a clearer understanding of contemporary hiring practices. For artists, the discussion demystifies recruiting steps and reframes preparation toward realistic signals of readiness. For educators, it offers a near-term snapshot of shifting expectations that can inform curriculum design and advising, as well as a rare opportunity to hear directly from hiring leaders

whose studio contexts differ dramatically, enabling more informed advising and curriculum alignment. For the broader community, the panel supports a transparent and illuminated view of the pathway from education to professional practice.

5 Moderator and Panelists

CK (Kaia) Olsen (University of Iowa). Kaia has worked throughout the industry as an artist, educator, and studio head for numerous award-winning productions including the VeggieTales® and Threads™ animated series. Kaia brings a multi-axis perspective that connects industry hiring realities with the challenges early-career artists face in a rapidly evolving field.

Kathleen Ruffalo (Framestore). Kathleen is Head of Recruitment for Framestore's U.S. offices. Since joining in 2012, she has helped shape the culture and creativity of the LA, New York, and Chicago studios. Kathleen focuses on assembling diverse skill sets that evolve alongside industry technology and team needs. She also co-chairs the U.S. chapter of the non-profit organization Access:VFX.

Tiffany Purkeypile (LAIKA). Tiffany is the Lead Creative Recruiter at LAIKA, bringing 15 years of feature film CG animation and VFX experience with a background in talent acquisition and artist management. After joining LAIKA in 2022, Tiffany has been

responsible for building a VFX team of over 300 artists in partnership with studio and creative leadership. Her production management and story artist experience, across CG and VFX pipelines enables her to quickly identify talent and support LAIKA's growing VFX and Technology teams with attention to building spaces for underrepresented communities.

Benjamin Noble (The Third Floor). Benjamin is a Recruiter at The Third Floor, Inc. A graduate of USC's Cinema and Media Studies Program, he first joined The Third Floor in 2021 as a Recruiting Coordinator. Since then, he has hired a wider variety of positions for numerous projects, including *Predator: Killer of Killers*. An animation nerd, he loves Studio Ghibli, the Rankin-Bass *Hobbit*, and hopes one day to finish *One Piece*.

Caitlin Dietz. Caitlin Dietz is a recruiting professional who is passionate about connecting creative talent with opportunities in animation. She spent a wonderful seven years at DreamWorks Animation, hiring across Feature and Series. With a decade of experience in animation, she brings a thoughtful, relationship-driven approach to supporting artists, teams and projects from development through delivery. She keeps her finger on the pulse of hiring trends and brings insight into talent strategy. Caitlin is fulfilled by connecting with creatives across all experience levels and learning about everyone's passions and goals - hoping to be a helping hand in finding their next job.